

The ~たい Form

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1. Basic Form

The ending ~たい is attached to a verb's **stem** to indicate a desire **to [verb]**.

The stem of a verb is just the ~ます form with ~ます cut off, so the type of verb doesn't matter.

ます FORM	→	STEM	→	~たい
た 食べます		た 食べ		た 食べたい

ます FORM	→	STEM	→	~たい
の 飲みます		の 飲み		の 飲みたい

ます FORM	→	STEM	→	~たい
い 行きます		い 行き		い 行きたい

Conjugation as an い-Adjective

Once you have changed a verb into the ~たい form, it conjugates further like an **い adjective**.

^た食べたいで
す。
*Want to eat.
(polite)*

^た食べたい。
*Want to eat.
(plain)*

^た食べたくない
です。
*Don't want to eat.
(polite)*

^た食べたくない。
*Don't want to eat.
(plain)*

^た食べたかった
です。
*Wanted to eat.
(polite)*

^た食べたかつ
た。
*Wanted to eat.
(plain)*

^た食べたくなか
ったです。
*Did not want to
eat. (polite)*

^た食べたくなか
った。
*Did not want to
eat. (plain)*

2. Particle Usage: を vs. が

Once a verb is in the **～たい** form, the direct object (what you want to eat/drink/wear/buy/etc.) is often marked by **が** instead of **を**.

Both are fine to use, with minimal difference, but you should be prepared to encounter each.

^{わたし}私は^たりんごを食べます。

I will eat an apple.

^{わたし}私は^たりんごを食べたいです。

I want to eat an apple. (using を)

^{わたし}私は^たりんごが食べたいです。

I want to eat an apple. (using が — also common)

^{せいふく}制服をきない。

I will not wear a school uniform.

^{せいふく}
制服をきたくない。

I do not want to wear a school uniform. (using を)

^{せいふく}
制服がきたくない。

I do not want to wear a school uniform. (using が)

Important: Particles other than を never change to が.

かれとあそぶ。

I will play with him.

かれとあそびたい。

I want to play with him. (と stays と)

かれにあわない。

I won't meet him.

かれにあいたくない。

I don't want to meet him. (に stays に)

3. Restrictions on Use

Unlike the English "want", in Japanese there are some restrictions on when you can use 〜たい.

1. Discussing your own desires.

わたし らいねん にほん い
私は来年日本に行きたいです。

Next year I want to go to Japan.

2. Asking questions about people's desires. (Be careful, as this can be rude in any language.)

あ、日本^{にほん}にいくの？ いいね。日本^{にほん}でなにをやりたい？

Ah, you're going to Japan? Awesome. What do you want to do there?

3. Speaking about general desires not specific to any individual.

じゃ、ビール^のを飲^ひみたい人^{ひと}は手^てをあげてください。

Okay, everyone who wants to drink beer, raise your hands!

4. Describing Other People's Desires

～たい is **not acceptable** for describing other people's desires.

You will be understood if you do, in most cases at least, but it is always better to do any of the following things:

Alternative 1: ～たがっている

Change ～たい to the verb ～たがっている.

This is best when **behaviour indicates desire**.

その犬^{いぬ}は晩御飯^{ばんごはん}を食^たべたがっている。

That dog (is behaving as though it) wants to eat dinner.

⚠ Since ～たがっている is still a verb, do **not** change を to が like with ～たい.

Alternative 2: ～たいそうです / ～たいそうだ

Add **そうです・そうだ** after **～たい** to indicate that you have **heard** the desire.

If you instead use **～たそうです** or **～たくなさそうです**, this means you **observed** the (lack of) desire instead.

あまりやりたくないそうです。

From what I can gather, they don't really want to do it. (hearsay)

Alternative 3: Quote the person

Quote the person as stating their desire, via attaching **～と言っている** to **～たい**.

かれは^{にほんご}日本語をべんきょうしたいと言っていた。

He was saying that he wants to study Japanese.

Summary Table

Form	Usage
～たい (plain)	Your own desire / general statements / questions
～たがっている	Describing others' desires (based on observable behavior)
～たいそうです	Hearsay — you heard someone else wants to do something
～たいと言っている	Quoting someone directly stating their desire

Based on the original document by Dr. Wes Robertson — reformatted for clarity.